

SUEDE DESIGNATHON 2026

WIN THE WEEKEND.

A competition operating plan for

Ethan • Darius • CC • Akari • Chloe

PROPOSAL • 1 SEP 2026

3

days to prepare

5

people • maximum team

One team. One loop. One story.

This is a 50-hour decision race.

FRI 4 SEP

5-8pm

Brief, rules, research, and concept lock.
Leave with one direction.

SAT 5 SEP

8am-8pm

Prove the core loop, build it, test it, then
freeze scope by 5pm.

SUN 6 SEP

8am-8pm

Make the story undeniable. Submit
early. Rehearse until calm.

CONFIRMED

In person · Wilkinson Building G04 · USYD · university students · teams of 3-5

UNKNOWN

2026 brief · rubric weights · pitch length · submission deadline · AI/IP rules · prizes

Rule: prepare the machine now. Do not pre-build the solution.

The winning shape is narrow, native, and retellable.

2025 · 1ST

HOT TOPIC

A redesigned comment experience under videos: one familiar behaviour, three prompts, a clear interaction, and no new destination app.

2025 · 2ND

LLAMALERT

A memorable llama flags misinformation, explains why, then turns learning into a tiny game. Instantly repeatable.

2025 · 3RD

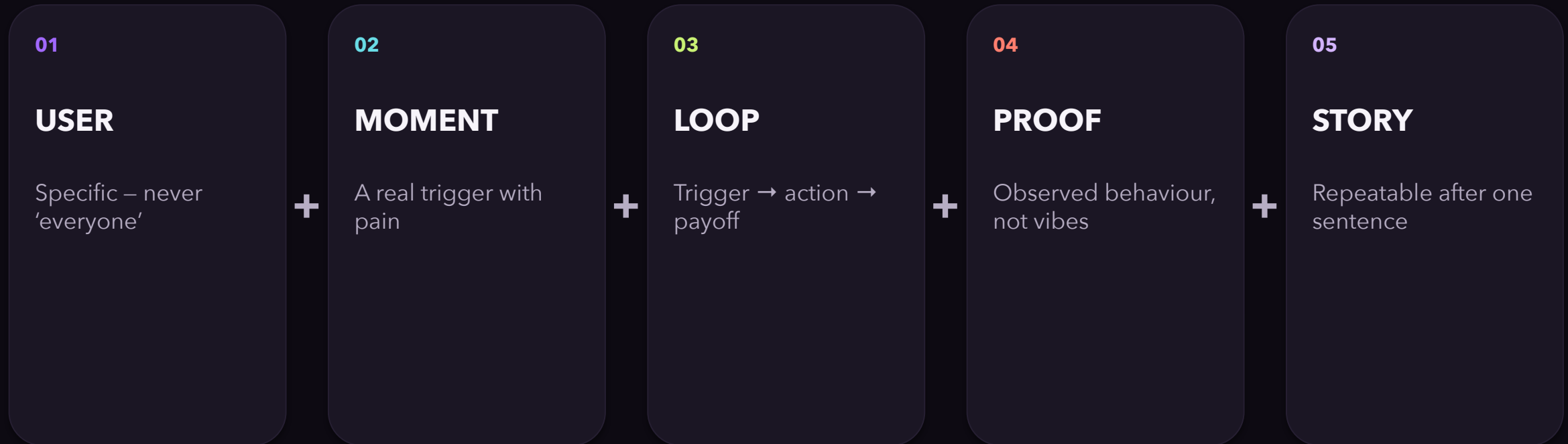
TOUCAN

A lightweight overlay at one moment of need. The team deliberately narrowed to learning, awareness, and convenience.

INFERENCE The judges rewarded a precise intervention in an existing routine – backed by proof and presented as a story.

Not another all-in-one app.

One user. One moment. One hero loop. One story.



If the idea needs a paragraph before the demo, it is not ready.

No concept reaches high-fi below 20 / 25.

01	Problem	specific + evidenced	1	2	3	4	5
02	Effectiveness	changes behaviour	1	2	3	4	5
03	Innovation	distinct mechanism	1	2	3	4	5
04	Craft	excellent in time	1	2	3	4	5
05	Story	instant recall	1	2	3	4	5

HISTORIC RUBRIC

SUEDE 2024 scored visual communication, problem, solution, innovation, and presentation.

Clear accountability beats polite overlap.

ETHAN**CAPTAIN / PRODUCT**

brief · scope · decisions · pitch

DARIUS**RESEARCH / PROOF**

interviews · tests · evidence

CC**UX / INTERACTION**

flow · states · prototype logic

AKARI**VISUAL / BRAND**

system · craft · motion

CHLOE**STORY / SUBMISSION**

deck · QA · backups · timing

Swap names after a 20-minute skills audit – keep these five ownership areas.

Prepare the operating system – legally.

TUE · ALIGN

Register + assign

- confirm 5 registrations
- finalise role owners
- shared Figma + drive
- empty research/deck templates
- ask organisers 4 rule questions

WED · REHEARSE

Run the machine

- 90-minute neutral mini-sprint
- concept scorecard drill
- five-minute interview
- lo-fi loop
- 60-second pitch
- test file permissions

THU · DE-RISK

Lower friction

- pack + charge everything
- fonts/tools available offline
- travel + 4:15pm arrival
- backup file system
- stop heavy work by 9pm
- sleep

Concept lock within 90 minutes of the brief.

5:00

**CAPTURE**

exact brief · rules · deliverables

5:30

**DECODE**

user · behaviour · constraint · success

5:45

**DIVERGE**

six ideas each → cluster to three

6:10

**SCORE**

kill weakly testable + feature-heavy ideas

6:30

**TALK**

five rapid user conversations

7:25

**LOCK**

one line · one loop · one direction

FRIDAY EXIT

**everyone says the
same one-line product**

Test low-fi early. Freeze features at 5pm.

08:00 **MAP** current journey + 5-7 frame hero loop

09:30 **LOW-FI** clickable core

10:30 **TEST** 3 users · observe, don't explain

11:15 **MENTOR 1** problem / solution logic

12:00 **BUILD** mid/high-fi + story in parallel

14:00 **TEST 2** comprehension + task success

15:30 **POLISH** trust · error · accessibility state

17:00 **FREEZE** no new scope

18:15 **PITCH 1** timed · brutal critique · backup demo

Saturday exit: a stranger completes the loop, explains the value, and remembers the mechanism.

Submission safety first. Polish second.

08:00-10:30

STABILISE

Fresh-eyes QA. Finish the deck and submission copy from the same story.

10:30-12:30

ATTACK

Ask a mentor: 'Why would this not advance?' Fix only decisive objections.

12:30 ONWARD

REHEARSE

Create a submittable checkpoint, then rehearse both 3- and 5-minute versions.

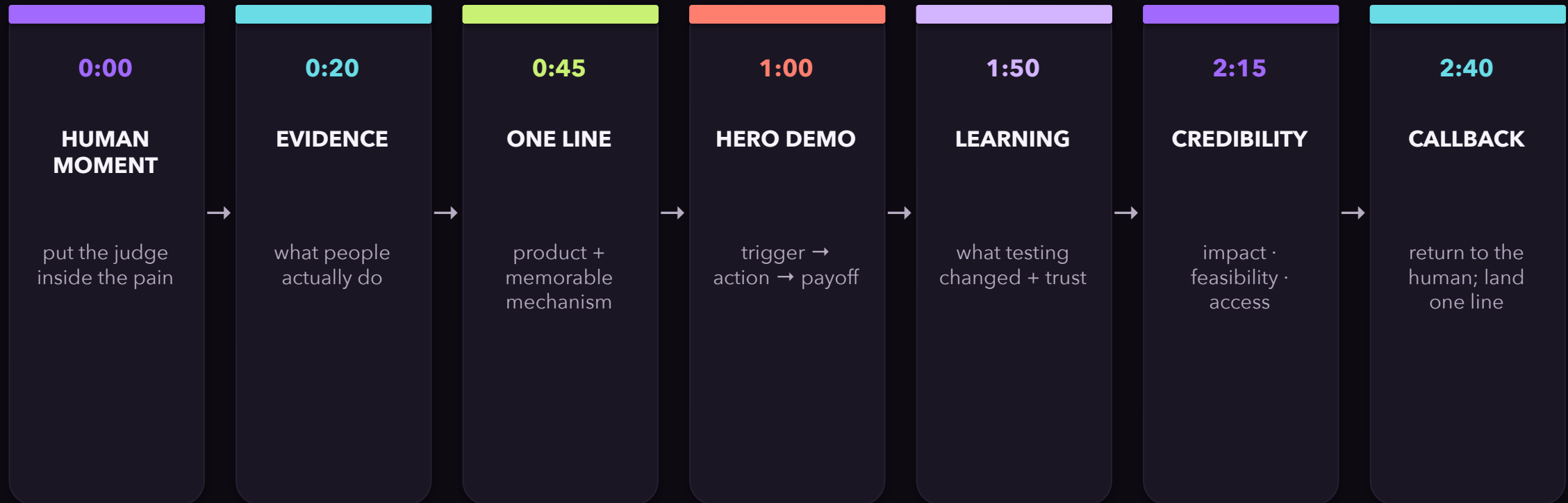
-90 MIN

A complete, tested submission exists before the official deadline.

Links work in incognito · assets disclosed · backup video on two devices · confirmation captured

After submission: freeze → hydrate → reset → present.

Demo the changed behaviour – not a feature tour.

**SPEAKER RULE**

One lead voice. Others own demo control and Q&A. Record a backup.

Most teams lose through scope, not talent.

- no 'app for everyone'
- no more than 3 concepts after hour one
- no high-fi before low-fi testing
- no feature after Saturday 5pm
- no fake evidence or technical claims
- no vague 'AI-powered' magic
- no live demo without backup
- no five-person pixel committee
- no all-nighter as a strategy
- no process-heavy pitch

Before adding anything: which score does this improve?

Win preparation starts with five boring certainties.

01

REGISTRATION

All five confirmation emails visible

02

ROLE LOCK

20-minute strengths audit tonight

03

ORGANISER CHECK

brief · deadline · AI/IP · rubric/pitch

04

90-MIN DRILL

run the neutral sprint tomorrow

05

ARRIVAL

Wilkinson G04 by 4:15pm Friday

Target: the clearest tested idea in the room – delivered by the calmest team.

Current organiser announcements override this deck.

2026 OFFICIAL

events.humanitix.com/suede-designaton-2026

SUEDE LIVE LINKS

linktr.ee/suedesociety

2025 OVERVIEW

suede-designathon-2025.devpost.com

2025 RULES

suede-designathon-2025.devpost.com/rules

2025 GALLERY

suede-designathon-2025.devpost.com/project-gallery

2024 RUBRIC

suede-designathon-2024.devpost.com

Research cut-off: 1 Sep 2026 · 2026 brief, rubric, deadline, judges, prizes, and AI/IP rules were not public.